

Sud-Aviation Caravelle



THE WORD MOST OFTEN ASSOCIATED with the Caravelle is “elegant”: many aircraft enthusiasts consider that the design team led by Pierre Satre at Sud-Est Aviation was responsible for one of the most aesthetically pleasing airplanes ever produced. The Caravelle is emblematic of the “glamour era” of jet flight in the 1960s.

In 1951 the French government decided to promote the development of the country’s first

jet airliner. They issued a specification for an airplane with a range of 1,242 miles (2,000km) and capacity for about 60 passengers. Because the French did not possess a forceful enough power plant for a two-engine design, the Sud-Est team initially submitted a three-engine design. Only after the Rolls-Royce Avon turbojet became available was a twin-engine design settled on.

The Caravelle prototype first flew in 1955, and by the time the first Caravelles entered service in 1959, Sud-Est had merged with Sud-Ouest to form Sud-Aviation. Initially, the omens for the aircraft were favorable. It was effectively the only short-to-medium haul jet airliner available, and its stylish looks provided strong passenger appeal. The first Caravelles were bought by Air France, the Scandinavian airline SAS, and the Brazilian airline Varig. In 1961, the aircraft broke into the valuable but notoriously patriotic American market with an order from United Airlines for 20 of the upgraded Caravelle VI model. Furthermore, Douglas, desperate for a product to run against the Boeing 727, seriously considered building Caravelles under license. In 1962, Douglas signed an agreement to market Caravelles in the US.

This, however, turned out to be the high point of the Caravelle’s fortunes. American airline operators



LARGER CAPACITY

The Caravelle 12 was able to carry up to 140 passengers (the original Caravelle accommodated only 52). The passenger cabin, shown above, was comfortable and well protected from external noise (it is said that a whisper at the back could be heard in the front).

Stylish, sweptback wings free of engines



were thirsty for jet airliners to operate on shorter routes, and it turned out that the French plane simply was not economical enough – its operating costs were too high for the number of passengers it could carry. When the British BAC 111 entered the market in the early 1960s, it could offer a better ratio of passengers and cargo carried to fuel consumption. Douglas, meanwhile, decided to produce its own aircraft, developing the immensely successful DC-9, and Boeing followed up with the 737. In a now crowded marketplace, the Caravelle was elbowed out.

POPULAR IN THE SIXTIES

Although production of the Caravelle halted in 1972 (after 282 had been made), it was the most successful jet airliner developed by any country in Western Europe. It paved the way for the later success of the Airbus series.



Two flight crew in cockpit

Flightdeck well forward in nose

Port forward door

Passenger windows

Nose-gear doors

Longer fuselage accommodates more passengers

